Switzerland Has Lost Nearly a Fifth of Its Glacier Ice in Five Years

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Switzerland's **glaciers** are shrinking fast, and 2026 was another hard year for them. The Swiss Academy of Sciences, using GLAMOS glacier **observations**, reports the **glaciers** lost more than 5 percent of their **ice volume** in 2026. That did not quite match the record losses of 2022, but **glaciers** thinned by 2.5 to 4 meters on average, and by as much as 10 meters in some lower areas. Major **glaciers** including the Rhône, Aletsch, and Clariden had their most severe melting on record in 2026. Bella Tola in Valais and Griessfirn in Glarus have disappeared. Over five years, Switzerland has lost nearly 20 percent of its glacier ice. The winter of 2025 to 2026 was among Switzerland's ten least snowy winters, and heat and dry weather from May to September 2026 sped up melting. On 76 days, the **freezing level** climbed above 4,000 meters, a new Swiss record. From July to September, **glaciers** released about 2.2 trillion liters of water, easing summer water shortages. But scientists warn this help cannot last, because shrinking **glaciers** will provide less **meltwater** in the future.

Word Treasure

glaciers -- Huge, slow-moving rivers of ice.
ice volume -- How much ice there is in total.
freezing level -- The height above which the air is cold enough for water to freeze.
meltwater -- Water that comes from melting ice and snow.
observations -- Careful watches and measurements made by scientists.

Background you need

Glaciers are huge rivers of ice that slowly move and melt.

Switzerland's glaciers lost nearly 20 percent of their ice in five years.

Heat and dry weather speed up melting, and melting glaciers release water but will provide less meltwater in the future.

Break it down

WHO: The Swiss Academy of Sciences, using GLAMOS glacier observations, and scientists.
WHAT: Switzerland's glaciers are shrinking fast, losing nearly a fifth of their ice in five years.
WHERE: Switzerland.
WHY: A little-snow winter plus heat and dry weather from May to September sped up melting.

Why it matters

Meltwater from glaciers helps with summer water shortages, so losing glaciers matters for water everyone uses.

Test what you remember

1. How much of their ice volume did Swiss glaciers lose in 2026?

- (A) Exactly 20 percent
- (B) Less than 1 percent
- (C) Half
- (D) More than 5 percent

2. Which year had record losses that 2026 did not quite match?

- (A) 2025
- (B) 2026
- (C) 2022
- (D) 2019

3. Which glaciers had their most severe melting on record in 2026?

- (A) The Rhône, Aletsch, and Clariden
- (B) None
- (C) Only Bella Tola
- (D) Only Griessfirn

4. What kind of winter was 2025 to 2026 in Switzerland?

- (A) The coldest ever
- (B) The snowiest ever
- (C) An average winter
- (D) Among the ten least snowy winters

5. On how many days did the freezing level climb above 4,000 meters?

- (A) 76 days
- (B) 20 days
- (C) 5 days
- (D) 10 days

6. From July to September, about how much water did glaciers release?

- (A) About 76 liters
- (B) About 2.2 trillion liters
- (C) About 2 liters
- (D) About 5 liters

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: A 4: D 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Scientists: Warn this help cannot last, because shrinking glaciers will provide less meltwater in the future.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):